

Tokyo Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** Japan
- **Language:** Japanese (English signage in major areas, limited English spoken)
- **Currency:** Japanese Yen (JPY, ¥)
- **Time Zone:** Japan Standard Time (JST, UTC+9)
- **Emergency Numbers:** Police 110, Fire/Ambulance 119
- **Dialing Code:** +81
- **Capital:** Tokyo (also the largest city)

Visa Requirements

Visa-Free Entry

Most visitors can enter Japan visa-free for tourism:

- **United States:** Visa-free for up to 90 days
- **European Union:** Visa-free for up to 90 days (all EU member states)
- **United Kingdom:** Visa-free for up to 90 days
- **Canada:** Visa-free for up to 90 days
- **Australia:** Visa-free for up to 90 days
- **New Zealand:** Visa-free for up to 90 days

Entry Requirements

- Valid passport (must be valid for duration of stay)
- Return or onward ticket (may be requested at immigration)
- Proof of sufficient funds (rarely requested but recommended)
- Completed disembarkation card (provided on flight)

Important Notes

- Visa-free stays are for tourism only (no paid work)
- Extension beyond 90 days requires visa application

- Working holiday visas available for select countries (ages 18-30)
- Check with Japanese embassy if your country is not listed above

Best Time to Visit

Spring (March - May)

- **Weather:** 10-20°C (50-68°F), gradually warming
- **Highlights:** Cherry blossom season (sakura) peaks early to mid-April
- **Crowds:** Very high during cherry blossom season
- **Events:** Hanami (cherry blossom viewing parties), Golden Week (late April/early May)
- **Pros:** Beautiful sakura, pleasant temperatures, outdoor festivals
- **Cons:** Extremely crowded, higher prices during Golden Week, brief rain showers

Summer (June - August)

- **Weather:** 25-35°C (77-95°F), hot and humid
- **Highlights:** Fireworks festivals, summer matsuri (festivals)
- **Crowds:** Moderate to high (peak in August)
- **Events:** Sumida River Fireworks, Obon Festival (mid-August)
- **Rainy Season:** June (tsuyu) brings frequent rain
- **Pros:** Vibrant festivals, long daylight hours, energetic atmosphere
- **Cons:** Very hot and humid, typhoon risk (late summer), rainy June

Fall (September - November)

- **Weather:** 15-25°C (59-77°F), comfortable and mild
- **Highlights:** Autumn foliage (koyo) peaks mid-November
- **Crowds:** Moderate (high during koyo season)
- **Events:** Tokyo Film Festival, various cultural festivals
- **Pros:** Comfortable temperatures, beautiful autumn colors, clear skies
- **Cons:** Early typhoons possible (September), popular leaf-viewing spots crowded

Winter (December - February)

- **Weather:** 5-12°C (41-54°F), cold but usually clear
- **Highlights:** New Year celebrations, winter illuminations

- **Crowds:** Low to moderate
- **Events:** New Year (Hatsumode shrine visits), winter illuminations
- **Pros:** Clear sunny days, fewer tourists, winter sports nearby (Hakuba, Nagano)
- **Cons:** Cold temperatures, some attractions have shorter hours

Recommended Visit: Spring (late March to May) or Fall (October to November) for best weather and seasonal beauty.

Top Attractions

Attraction	District	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit
Senso-ji Temple	Asakusa	Free	6:00-17:00	Early morning (7-8am) to avoid crowds
Tokyo Skytree	Sumida	¥2,100-3,100	9:00-21:00	Sunset (book in advance)
Shibuya Crossing	Shibuya	Free	24/7	Evening (6-8pm) for maximum activity
Meiji Shrine	Harajuku	Free	Sunrise-sunset	Early morning on weekdays
Tsukiji Outer Market	Tsukiji	Free	5:00-14:00	Morning (8-10am) for freshest seafood
Imperial Palace East Gardens	Chiyoda	Free	9:00-16:00 (closed Mon/Fri)	Weekday mornings
TeamLab Borderless	Odaiba	¥3,200	10:00-19:00	Weekdays (pre-book essential)
Tokyo Tower	Minato	¥1,200	9:00-23:00	Evening for city lights
Ueno Park	Ueno	Free (museums vary)	5:00-23:00	Cherry blossom season or museum visits
Akihabara Electric Town	Akihabara	Free (shops vary)	10:00-20:00	Afternoon/evening

Additional Must-See Attractions

- **Shinjuku Gyoen National Garden:** Beautiful gardens (¥500, 9:00-16:30)
- **Harajuku Takeshita Street:** Youth culture and fashion hub (free, shop hours vary)
- **Roppongi Hills Mori Art Museum:** Contemporary art with city views (¥1,800, 10:00-22:00)

- **Odaiba:** Futuristic waterfront area with shopping and entertainment
- **Tokyo National Museum:** Japan's largest museum (¥1,000, 9:30-17:00, closed Mondays)

Neighborhoods & Districts

Shinjuku

- **Character:** Tokyo's busiest district, business hub by day, entertainment at night
- **Must-See:** Shinjuku Gyoen, Tokyo Metropolitan Government Building (free observatory), Golden Gai bar district
- **Food:** Omoide Yokocho (Memory Lane) for yakitori, department store food halls
- **Transport:** Shinjuku Station (world's busiest station - be prepared!)
- **Best For:** Shopping, nightlife, skyscrapers, diverse dining

Shibuya

- **Character:** Youth culture epicenter, fashion and technology
- **Must-See:** Shibuya Crossing, Hachiko statue, Shibuya Sky observation deck
- **Food:** Conveyor belt sushi, trendy cafes, international restaurants
- **Transport:** Shibuya Station (major hub)
- **Best For:** Shopping, people-watching, nightlife, modern Tokyo vibe

Asakusa

- **Character:** Traditional old Tokyo atmosphere, historic temples
- **Must-See:** Senso-ji Temple, Nakamise Shopping Street, Sumida River cruise
- **Food:** Traditional Japanese sweets, tempura restaurants, street food
- **Transport:** Asakusa Station (Ginza Line)
- **Best For:** Traditional culture, temples, classic Tokyo experience

Ginza

- **Character:** Upscale shopping district, luxury brands, high-end dining
- **Must-See:** Ginza Six shopping complex, Kabukiza Theatre, pedestrian paradise (weekends)
- **Food:** High-end sushi, department store food halls, fine dining
- **Transport:** Ginza Station (multiple lines)
- **Best For:** Luxury shopping, window shopping, gourmet dining, theater

Harajuku

- **Character:** Youth fashion, quirky street style, pop culture
- **Must-See:** Takeshita Street, Omotesando (high-end avenue), Meiji Shrine
- **Food:** Crepes, rainbow cotton candy, trendy cafes
- **Transport:** Harajuku Station (JR Yamanote Line)
- **Best For:** Fashion, youth culture, unique shopping, Instagram spots

Akihabara

- **Character:** Electronics and otaku (anime/manga) culture hub
- **Must-See:** Multi-story electronics shops, anime stores, maid cafes, retro game shops
- **Food:** Themed cafes, ramen shops, casual dining
- **Transport:** Akihabara Station (JR Yamanote Line)
- **Best For:** Electronics, anime/manga merchandise, gaming culture

Food & Dining

Signature Dishes to Try

Ramen

- **Shoyu Ramen:** Soy sauce-based, classic Tokyo style
- **Tonkotsu Ramen:** Rich pork bone broth
- **Miso Ramen:** Fermented soybean paste base
- **Tsukemen:** Dipping ramen with separate broth
- **Price Range:** ¥800-1,500 per bowl
- **Where:** Ichiran (chain), Afuri (yuzu shio ramen), Ippudo

Sushi

- **Conveyor Belt Sushi (Kaiten-zushi):** Budget-friendly, casual (¥100-500 per plate)
- **Sushi Restaurant:** Mid-range quality (¥2,000-5,000 per person)
- **High-End Sushi (Omakase):** Chef's choice tasting menu (¥10,000-30,000+)
- **Sushi Etiquette:** Eat in one bite, wasabi already applied by chef, can use fingers or chopsticks
- **Where:** Sushi Dai (Tsukiji), Sushiro (conveyor belt chain), Sukiyabashi Jiro (high-end, reservations essential)

Other Must-Try Foods

- **Tempura:** Lightly battered deep-fried seafood and vegetables (¥1,500-8,000)
- **Tonkatsu:** Breaded pork cutlet (¥1,000-2,000)
- **Okonomiyaki:** Savory pancake with various ingredients
- **Yakitori:** Grilled chicken skewers (¥200-500 per skewer)
- **Udon/Soba:** Noodle soups (¥500-1,200)
- **Wagyu Beef:** Premium Japanese beef (¥5,000-20,000)

Dining Price Ranges

- **Budget (¥500-1,500):** Convenience store meals, fast food, ramen shops, conveyor belt sushi, standing bars
- **Mid-Range (¥2,000-5,000):** Casual restaurants, izakayas, good sushi restaurants, set meals (teishoku)
- **High-End (¥10,000+):** Fine dining, omakase sushi, kaiseki (multi-course traditional), wagyu specialists

Dining Tips

- **Izakaya:** Japanese gastropubs, order small plates and drinks, lively atmosphere
- **Set Meals:** Look for "teishoku" lunch sets (great value, ¥800-1,500)
- **Plastic Food Models:** Displayed outside restaurants, point if you can't read Japanese
- **Vending Machines:** Many ramen shops use ticket vending machines at entrance
- **No Tipping:** Tipping is not customary and may be refused
- **Wet Towel (Oshibori):** Use before eating, not during or after

Transportation

From Airports

Narita International Airport (NRT)

- **Location:** 60 km east of Tokyo (1-1.5 hours to central Tokyo)
- **Narita Express (N'EX):** Train to Tokyo Station, Shinjuku, Shibuya (¥3,000-3,200, 60-90 min)
- **Keisei Skyliner:** Train to Ueno (¥2,500, 41 min), connects to metro
- **Airport Limousine Bus:** Direct to major hotels (¥3,200, 90-120 min)
- **Budget Option:** Local trains (¥1,200-1,500, 90+ min with transfers)

Haneda Airport (HND)

- **Location:** 15 km south of Tokyo (30-45 minutes to central Tokyo)
- **Tokyo Monorail:** To Hamamatsucho Station (¥500, 20 min), connects to JR Yamanote Line
- **Keikyu Line:** To Shinagawa Station (¥300, 15 min), connects to JR and metro
- **Airport Limousine Bus:** Direct to major hotels (¥1,300, 30-60 min)
- **Taxi:** ¥6,000-8,000 to central Tokyo (traffic dependent)

Metro and Trains

IC Cards (Essential!)

- **Suica or Pasma:** Rechargeable smart cards for all trains, buses, some shops
- **Purchase:** Any station ticket machine (¥2,000 including ¥500 deposit)
- **Benefits:** No need to buy individual tickets, tap to enter/exit, works nationwide
- **Refund:** Deposit refundable when you return the card

Metro System

- **Lines:** 13 metro lines (color-coded), easy to navigate
- **Fares:** ¥170-320 depending on distance
- **Peak Hours:** Avoid 7:30-9:30am and 5:30-7:30pm if possible (extremely crowded)
- **Last Trains:** Around midnight (check specific line, plan accordingly)
- **Navigation Apps:** Google Maps, Hyperdia (essential for route planning)

JR Yamanote Line

- **Description:** Circular line connecting major stations (Tokyo, Shinjuku, Shibuya, etc.)
- **Interval:** Every 3-5 minutes
- **Fare:** ¥140-200 per ride
- **Tip:** Great for orientation and major sightseeing areas

JR Pass

- **What:** Unlimited JR trains nationwide (including shinkansen)
- **Cost:** 7-day pass ¥29,650 (must purchase before arriving in Japan)
- **Worth It?:** Only if taking shinkansen trips outside Tokyo (e.g., Kyoto, Osaka, Hakone)
- **Tokyo-Only:** Not cost-effective for Tokyo sightseeing alone

Taxis

- **Availability:** Abundant, but expensive
- **Base Fare:** ¥500-730 (first 1-2 km), then ¥80-90 per 250-300m
- **Tips:** Doors open automatically, driver rarely speaks English (have address in Japanese)
- **Apps:** Japan Taxi app (English available)

Walking and Biking

- **Walking:** Tokyo is walkable between nearby areas, excellent sidewalks
- **Biking:** Bike rentals available but limited bike lanes, need to follow rules strictly
- **E-Bikes/Scooters:** Emerging options, check local apps

Cultural Tips & Customs

Greetings and Etiquette

- **Bowing:** Standard greeting (slight bow for casual, deeper for formal)
- **Business Cards:** Present and receive with both hands, examine carefully
- **Handshakes:** Uncommon, but acceptable with foreigners
- **Eye Contact:** Less intense than Western cultures, staring considered rude
- **Pointing:** Use whole hand, not index finger

Social Customs

- **Shoes:** Remove when entering homes, traditional restaurants, temples, some hotels
- **Slippers:** Provided indoors; special toilet slippers only in bathroom
- **Quiet Culture:** Speak quietly in public, especially trains (no phone calls on trains!)
- **Queuing:** Always form orderly lines, never cut
- **Public Behavior:** Avoid eating while walking, public displays of affection minimal

Tipping

- **Rule:** Do NOT tip anywhere (restaurants, taxis, hotels)
- **Reason:** Considered insulting, excellent service is expected standard
- **Exception:** None for tourists (service charge included in high-end restaurants)

Chopstick Etiquette

- **Don't:** Stick chopsticks upright in rice (funeral ritual)
- **Don't:** Pass food chopstick-to-chopstick (funeral ritual)
- **Don't:** Point with chopsticks or wave them around
- **Do:** Rest chopsticks on provided holder or plate edge
- **Sharing:** Take from shared plates with opposite end of your chopsticks

Onsen (Hot Spring) Etiquette

- **Tattoos:** Many onsen prohibit tattoos (traditional yakuza association)
- **Bathing:** Wash thoroughly at shower stations BEFORE entering communal bath
- **Naked:** Bathing suits not allowed, separate gender facilities
- **Towel:** Small towel allowed but not in water (place on head or side)
- **Hair:** Tie long hair up

Gift Giving

- **Omiyage:** Regional food souvenirs expected when visiting someone
- **Wrapping:** Presentation matters, often beautifully wrapped
- **Refusing:** Polite to refuse once or twice before accepting

Safety & Health

General Safety

- **Crime:** Extremely low crime rate, one of the world's safest cities
- **Lost Items:** High chance of recovery (turn in to police koban or station lost & found)
- **Walking at Night:** Generally safe in all areas
- **Scams:** Very rare, mostly limited to tourist traps in nightlife areas (Roppongi, Kabukicho)
- **Emergency:** Call 110 (police) or 119 (fire/ambulance), some English support

Earthquake Awareness

- **Frequency:** Minor earthquakes common (usually not felt strongly)
- **Preparedness:** Buildings earthquake-resistant, follow instructions if major quake occurs
- **If Indoors:** Take cover under sturdy furniture, stay away from windows

- **If Outdoors:** Move away from buildings, power lines, go to open spaces
- **Tsunami:** If near coast and feel strong quake, move to high ground immediately

Health and Medical

- **Healthcare Quality:** Excellent, but expensive without insurance
- **Travel Insurance:** Highly recommended
- **Pharmacies:** Limited over-the-counter options, bring necessary medications
- **Hospitals with English:** Tokyo Midtown Clinic, St. Luke's International Hospital
- **Clinics:** Convenience stores (konbini) have basic first aid supplies

Convenience Store Essentials

- **7-Eleven, Lawson, FamilyMart:** Open 24/7, found everywhere
- **Services:** ATMs, food, drinks, toiletries, phone chargers, umbrellas
- **ATMs:** 7-Eleven ATMs accept most foreign cards (many bank ATMs don't)

Allergies and Dietary Restrictions

- **Language Barrier:** Limited English on menus, few staff speak English
- **Allergy Cards:** Download Japanese allergy cards showing your restrictions
- **Vegetarian/Vegan:** Challenging, even "vegetarian" dishes may have fish stock
- **Halal:** Limited options, check Tokyo Halal Guide app
- **Gluten-Free:** Difficult, soy sauce contains wheat (tamari is gluten-free alternative)

Practical Information

Electricity and Adapters

- **Voltage:** 100V (lower than US 110V, most devices work fine)
- **Frequency:** 50Hz (Eastern Japan including Tokyo)
- **Plug Type:** Type A and B (same as USA - two flat prongs)
- **Adapters:** US devices work directly, EU/UK need adapters (buy at airport or electronics stores)

Internet and WiFi

- **WiFi:** Excellent free WiFi at stations, convenience stores, cafes, many shops
- **Pocket WiFi:** Rent portable WiFi router at airport (¥800-1,200/day, unlimited data)

- **SIM Cards:** Tourist SIM cards available at airport (data-only, 7-30 days)
- **Hotels:** Most hotels have free WiFi
- **Coverage:** Excellent 4G/5G coverage throughout Tokyo

Money and ATMs

- **Cash Culture:** Still very cash-dependent, carry ¥10,000-20,000 daily
- **Credit Cards:** Accepted at major stores, hotels, restaurants (not all small shops)
- **ATMs:** 7-Eleven and Japan Post ATMs accept foreign cards (most bank ATMs don't)
- **Currency Exchange:** Airport, major stations, some hotels (rates better at dedicated exchange shops)
- **Cashless:** IC cards (Suica/Pasmo) accepted at many shops, convenience stores

Business Hours

- **Shops:** Usually 10:00-20:00 (department stores 10:00-20:00 or 21:00)
- **Restaurants:** Lunch 11:30-14:00, Dinner 17:30-22:00 (varies widely)
- **Convenience Stores:** 24/7
- **Temples/Shrines:** Usually sunrise to sunset (some specific hours)
- **Museums:** Usually 9:00-17:00, closed Mondays (many)

Language Tips

- **English:** Limited outside tourist areas, younger people more likely to speak some English
- **Essential Phrases:**
 - Sumimasen (excuse me / sorry)
 - Arigatou gozaimasu (thank you very much)
 - Eigo ga hanasemasu ka? (Do you speak English?)
 - Kore kudasai (This please - while pointing)
- **Apps:** Google Translate (offline mode helpful), Papago (alternative)
- **Writing:** Address in Japanese essential for taxis, restaurants

Helpful Apps

- **Google Maps:** Navigation, train routes, walking directions (essential)
- **Hyperdia:** Detailed train schedules and routes
- **Japan Official Travel App:** Tourism info, maps, route search

- **PayPay:** Popular digital payment app
- **Tabelog:** Restaurant reviews (Japanese Yelp)

Seasons and Packing

- **Spring:** Light jacket, layers, umbrella (cherry blossom season)
- **Summer:** Light breathable clothes, sunscreen, hat, umbrella (for sun and rain)
- **Fall:** Light jacket, layers (similar to spring)
- **Winter:** Warm coat, layers (buildings well-heated indoors)
- **Year-Round:** Comfortable walking shoes (you'll walk a lot!)

Public Holidays

- **New Year:** December 29 - January 3 (many businesses closed)
- **Golden Week:** Late April - early May (very crowded, book ahead)
- **Obon:** Mid-August (summer holiday, some businesses close)
- **Silver Week:** Late September (occasional long weekend)
- **Note:** Museums often closed on Mondays, or next day if Monday is a holiday

Day Trip Destinations

Mount Fuji and Hakone

- **Distance:** 100 km southwest (2 hours by train)
- **Highlights:** Mount Fuji views, hot springs, scenic Lake Ashi
- **Transport:** Odakyu Romance Car from Shinjuku
- **Duration:** Full day or overnight

Nikko

- **Distance:** 140 km north (2 hours by train)
- **Highlights:** Toshogu Shrine (UNESCO), natural scenery, waterfalls
- **Transport:** JR or Tobu Railway from Asakusa/Shinjuku
- **Duration:** Full day

Kamakura

- **Distance:** 50 km south (1 hour by train)

- **Highlights:** Great Buddha statue, temples, beach town atmosphere
- **Transport:** JR Yokosuka Line from Tokyo Station
- **Duration:** Half day or full day

Yokohama

- **Distance:** 30 km south (30 minutes by train)
- **Highlights:** Chinatown, waterfront, Minato Mirai 21
- **Transport:** JR or metro from central Tokyo
- **Duration:** Half day

Budget Guide

Daily Budget Estimates

Budget Traveler (¥8,000-12,000/day): - Accommodation: Hostel/capsule hotel (¥3,000-4,000) - Meals: Convenience stores, ramen, fast food (¥2,000-3,000) - Transport: Metro pass (¥1,000) - Activities: Free temples, parks, walking tours (¥1,000-2,000)

Mid-Range Traveler (¥15,000-25,000/day): - Accommodation: Business hotel/Airbnb (¥8,000-12,000) - Meals: Mix of casual restaurants and izakayas (¥4,000-6,000) - Transport: IC card for metro, occasional taxi (¥1,500-2,000) - Activities: Paid attractions, museums (¥2,000-4,000)

Luxury Traveler (¥35,000+/day): - Accommodation: High-end hotel (¥20,000-50,000+) - Meals: Fine dining, omakase sushi (¥10,000-20,000+) - Transport: Private car, taxis (¥3,000-5,000) - Activities: Premium experiences (¥5,000-10,000)

Final Tips

1. **Learn Basic Phrases:** Even simple "arigatou" (thank you) goes a long way
2. **Carry Cash:** Despite being high-tech, Japan is still cash-heavy
3. **Download Offline Maps:** For when WiFi is unavailable
4. **Respect Quiet Culture:** Keep voices low on trains and in public
5. **Try Everything:** Food is safe and delicious, be adventurous
6. **Early Bird:** Many attractions and restaurants less crowded in morning
7. **Buy IC Card Immediately:** Makes transportation seamless
8. **Don't Rush:** Tokyo is vast, focus on 2-3 neighborhoods per day

9. **Street Food:** Limited compared to other Asian cities (hygiene regulations)
10. **Enjoy the Experience:** Tokyo blends ultra-modern and traditional beautifully

Emergency Contacts: - Police: 110 - Fire/Ambulance: 119 - Japan Helpline (English):
0570-000-911 - Tourist Information Center: +81-3-3201-3331

Tokyo is a city of contrasts - where ancient temples sit beside neon-lit skyscrapers, where cutting-edge technology meets centuries-old traditions. Respect local customs, stay curious, and immerse yourself in one of the world's most fascinating cities.

Enjoy your Tokyo adventure! (Welcome to Tokyo!)